

The first *hundred* days decide the deal.

A point of view for chief executives and finance officers on post-merger integration in GCC financial services.

THE ARGUMENT

The deal closes. The work *begins*.

The signature is the easy part. GCC financial services is consolidating: banks, NBFIs and capital markets institutions are merging to reach the scale their regulators and shareholders expect. Every deal model promises synergies. The published record says most acquirers never see them: decades of research put the share of deals that underperform expectations at 70 to 90 per cent.

Perception flatters the numbers. When Eight Advisory interviewed 92 European acquirers responsible for 700 deals, 71% called their transactions successful. Only 40% had actually achieved the synergies that justified the price. The gap between the two figures is unmanaged integration: targets set in due diligence with no delivery plan, and attention that moves on once the deal closes.

Day one is an operational test, not a ceremony. Customers, regulators and staff all judge the merger on its first day. When one regional group integrated four businesses at once, the standard was set in advance: legal-day readiness, transparent governance and a seamless customer day-one experience across 200,000+ customers. Zero disruption was a design requirement, not a hope.

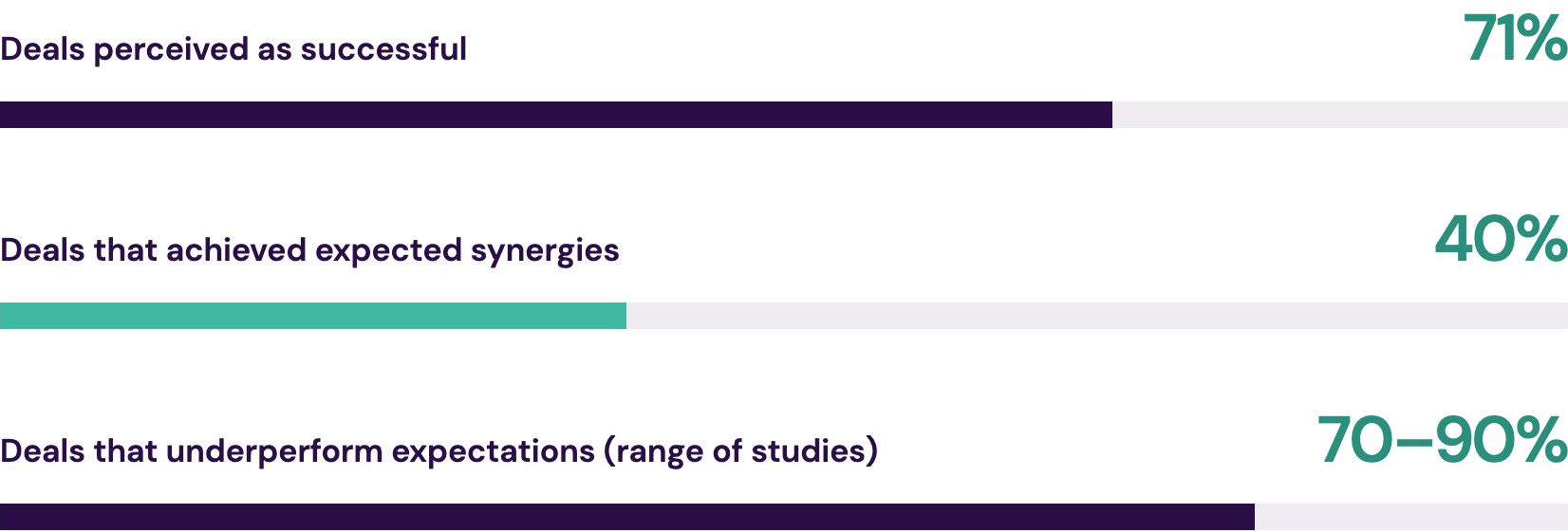
Why value is won or lost between signature and day one, and what the integration record actually shows.

“A synergy target without a delivery plan is a *press release*.”

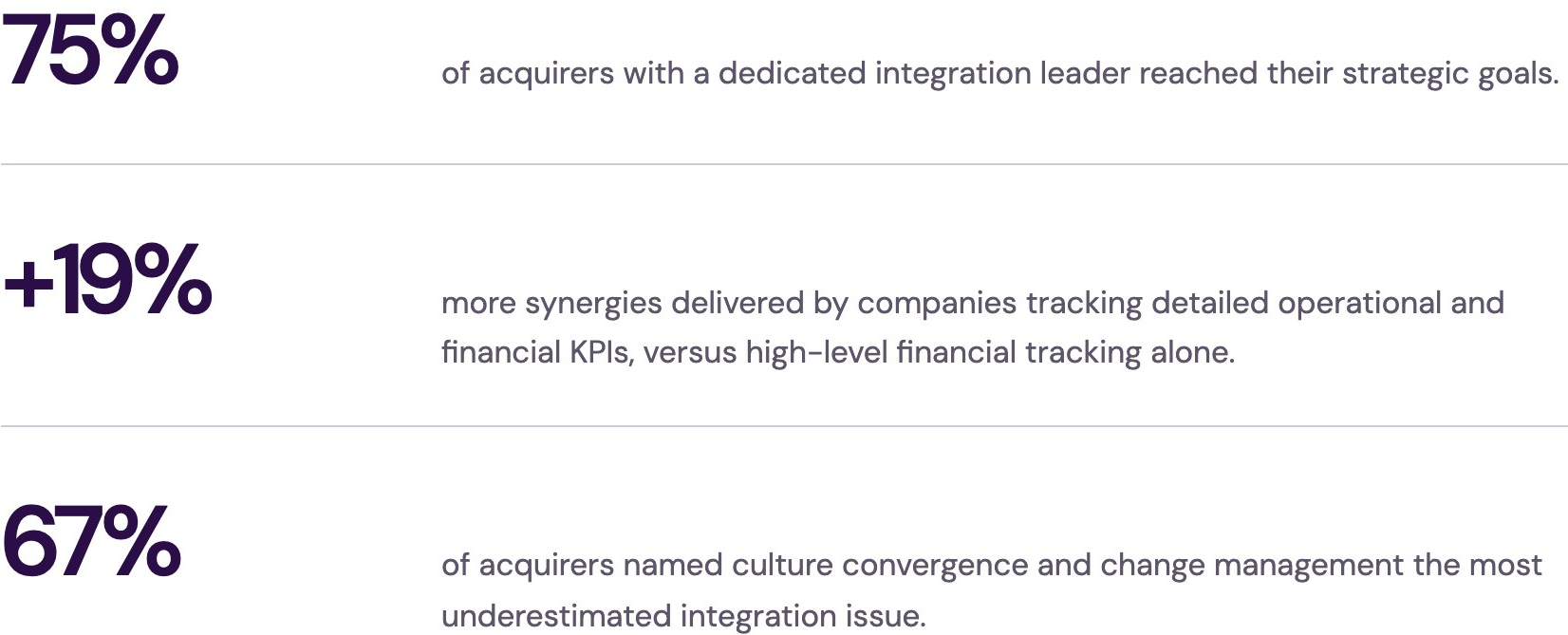
THE EVIDENCE

What the integration record *shows*.

PERCEIVED SUCCESS VS DELIVERED SYNERGIES



WHAT MOVES THE ODDS



Sources: Eight Advisory, European M&A study, 2023 (92 companies, 700+ deals); Harvard Business Review and Wharton reviews of M&A outcome research. Aspiro analysis.

THE FRAMEWORK

Four disciplines of a clean *integration*.

01

One integration owner

A Transformation PMO with a named leader, reporting to the CEO, accountable for the whole programme rather than any single workstream.

03

Day one as a rehearsed event

Legal-day readiness tested before it counts: customer journeys, regulatory filings, people moves and communications, walked through end to end.

02

Synergies as initiatives

Every deal-model synergy translated into a named initiative with an owner, a date and operational KPIs. No target lives only in the model.

04

Culture managed like a workstream

The most underestimated risk gets the same governance as the balance sheet: leadership alignment, retention of key people, honest communication.



CASE STUDY

Four businesses, one day one, zero *disruption*.

Zero

CUSTOMER DISRUPTION AT LEGAL DAY

Transformation PMO — multi-business integration

Asset Management, Retail Brokerage, Margin Lending and Wealth Management, integrated under one PMO.

THE CHALLENGE

Integrating four regulated businesses — \$205M of businesses serving 200,000+ customers — into one institution, with a fixed legal day and no tolerance for customer-facing failure.

WHAT WE DID

Ran a PMO-led integration across all four businesses: legal-day readiness testing, transparent governance for every workstream, and a single escalation route to the executive.

THE OUTCOME

A seamless customer day-one experience. Zero disruption across 200,000+ customers, with governance the Board and regulators could inspect at any point.

Zero

Disruption at legal day

200,000+

Customers through day one seamlessly

\$205M

Of businesses integrated under one PMO



WHAT TO DO ON MONDAY

Four moves before the ink *dries*.

- 01

Name the integration leader now

Before signature, not after. The 75% success rate belongs to acquirers who did.
- 02

Turn the model into initiatives

Each synergy gets an owner, a date and operational KPIs — tracked at that level.
- 03

Rehearse day one

Walk every customer journey and regulatory filing before the day it counts.
- 04

Budget for culture

Two thirds of acquirers underestimated it. Give it a workstream, a leader and a plan.

Leading with clarity.
Delivering the *difference*.

Start a conversation

ABOUT ASPIRO

Aspiro is an independent, investor-free management consultancy for GCC financial institutions, founded in Dubai in 2015 with offices in Riyadh and London. Its partners carry 100+ years of senior leadership experience, backed by a network of 8,000+ specialists.

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